

TRUE

MEDIUM RISK

Vacuum packaging removes oxygen, which slows mold and bacterial spoilage, but low-acid perishable foods still need refrigeration to stay safe. Without refrigeration, dangerous bacteria can grow even in vacuum packaging. Freezing or canning are necessary for longer term storage.

Why people believe it: Many people trust vacuum packaging alone to preserve food safely and think refrigeration may not always be needed.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

TRUE

MEDIUM RISK

Recipes like homemade mayonnaise or eggnog containing raw or lightly cooked eggs can be a risk for Salmonella infection. Using pasteurized eggs or egg products eliminates this risk and keeps your food safe.

Why people believe it: Many people hesitate to change traditional recipes, fearing taste or quality loss, or overlook the risk from raw eggs.

Source: PNW 250 You can prevent food borne illness

FALSE

HIGH RISK

Freezing canned foods is not a safe preservation method. Home-canned foods must be processed and stored properly at room temperature. Freezing can cause jars to crack or lids to loosen, which risks contamination. Additionally, freezing does not kill bacteria like botulism spores that can grow in canned low-acid foods.

Why people believe it: People often think freezing everything halts all bacteria because it slows bacterial growth. Also, reusing home-canned foods for freezing seems convenient and logical.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

FALSE

HIGH RISK

Flour can contain harmful bacteria like E. coli, and because it is raw and dry, these bacteria are not killed until the flour is cooked. Eating raw dough or batter made with uncooked flour can cause foodborne illness. It's important to avoid tasting raw dough or batter and to cook flour-containing foods thoroughly.

Why people believe it: People see dry flour as stable and safe and associate cooking safety only with meats or fresh produce, leading to underestimating flour's risks.

Source: PNW 717 Dangers lurking in your flour

FALSE

HIGH RISK

Home pasteurization attempts often use too low a temperature or too short a time, failing to kill all harmful bacteria. Proper pasteurization requires heating milk to at least 161°F for 15 seconds or 145°F for 30 minutes. Unsafe home pasteurization may give a false sense of security and put people at risk for serious illness.

Why people believe it: Some people think they can replicate commercial pasteurization with home heating methods to enjoy raw milk benefits while being safe.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

TRUE

LOW RISK

Hot pack involves briefly boiling fruits before packing in jars, which helps retain color, flavor, texture, and reduces floating fruit. It also usually shortens processing time compared to raw pack. Though some prefer raw pack for firmer texture, hot pack has distinct advantages.

Why people believe it: Some cooks doubt heating fruit first, thinking it reduces nutrient quality or texture. Traditional methods often favored raw packing for fruit firmness.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

Adding bottled lemon juice or citric acid is necessary for safety when canning low-acid fruits such as figs and Asian pears. Without acidification, the risk of botulism increases. Using the recommended amounts ensures safety without causing excessive sourness.

Why people believe it: Many find the added acid makes the fruit taste too tart, so they skip it, influenced by tradition or taste preferences.

FALSE

HIGH RISK

Acidifying low-acid fruits such as figs and Asian pears with lemon juice before canning is important to make the product safe. Without this step, harmful bacteria may survive in the low-acid environment. Adding the recommended amount of bottled lemon juice helps ensure the acidity is high enough for safe water bath canning.

Why people believe it: Some people rely on old family recipes or assume that fruits are naturally acidic enough to be safe without added acid. Traditional recipes may omit acidifiers because taste or texture was prioritized over safety in the past.

Source: SP 50-1003 Laws of salsa with recipes

FALSE

HIGH RISK

Reusable metal bands can be used multiple times, but flat canning lids should never be reused. Each lid has a sealing compound designed for one use only. Reusing lids risks poor seals, leading to spoilage or dangerous microbial growth inside the jar.

Why people believe it: Some people want to save money or avoid waste by reusing lids. This might come from reusing other food packaging or from misunderstanding instructions from earlier home canning practices.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

FALSE

HIGH RISK

It is important to leave the recommended headspace (usually 1/2 inch) between the fruit or liquid and the jar rim. Overfilling can cause food to bubble out during processing, interfering with the seal and potentially leading to spoilage or unsafe canned goods.

Why people believe it: People may think max filling is better to store more food or prevent air exposure. This belief may come from misunderstanding headspace importance from older cookbooks or visual intuition.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

TRUE

MEDIUM RISK

Tomatoes have borderline acidity, with pH near 4.6, so adding bottled lemon juice or vinegar provides consistent acidity to prevent harmful bacteria growth. This acidification ensures tomatoes can be safely processed in a boiling water canner. Without added acid, tomatoes may not be safe to can.

Why people believe it: This practice is common in many canning guides and home canning traditions, where natural tomato acidity varies and bottled acid is a reliable way to ensure safety.

Source: PNW 300 Canning tomatoes and tomato products

TRUE

LOW RISK

Green tomatoes can be used in place of red tomatoes in tested salsa recipes as long as you do not alter the acid amounts or processing times. Some research-tested recipes even call for green tomatoes, maintaining the safety of the finished product by keeping correct acidity levels intact.

Why people believe it: People often think green tomatoes are less acidic or unsafe because they are unripe, leading to doubts about including them in salsa.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables

FALSE

HIGH RISK

Salsas are acidified foods combining low-acid and acid ingredients. Only tested recipes have the proper acidity to prevent dangerous bacteria growth. Creating your own recipe risks unsafe acidity levels that can cause botulism. Always use research-tested recipes for canning salsa or freeze your original recipe instead.

Why people believe it: Many people trust family recipes or like to customize flavors, believing that traditional methods or personal tweaks are safe because it 'cooked down' or 'boiled enough.'

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables

FALSE

HIGH RISK

Boiling salsa before jar filling is part of some recipe steps but does not replace the required boiling water bath or pressure canning process. Proper processing time in a water bath canner is crucial to eliminate bacteria and ensure safety. Skipping or shortening processing times puts you at risk of botulism.

Why people believe it: People may think that making salsa hot or boiling it first 'kills everything,' so extra processing is unnecessary, especially in homemade batches.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

FALSE

MEDIUM RISK

While it might seem adding more vinegar increases safety, altering acid levels beyond what tested recipes specify can disrupt the product's texture, flavor, and pH balance. It can potentially lead to unsafe preservation results or inferior quality. Always follow the exact acid amounts in tested recipes.

Why people believe it: People intuitively think 'more acid equals safer food' and may add extra vinegar for tangy flavor or perceived extra safety.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables

TRUE

MEDIUM RISK

Boiling low acid home-canned foods for 10 minutes before eating is an important safety measure to destroy any botulism toxin that might be present. This extra step is recommended because botulism toxin can be deadly even if the canned food looks normal.

Why people believe it: Some doubt boiling is necessary if the food looks, smells, and tastes fine. Boiling is considered extra precaution by some, but skepticism exists because it changes food quality.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

Soaking and pre-cooking dried beans makes them safe and improves texture when canned. Skipping this step can lead to poor quality and unsafe results.

Why people believe it: Traditional canning methods sometimes omit soaking, but modern research shows it's essential for safety and quality.

Source: PNW 450 Canning smoked fish at home

FALSE

HIGH RISK

Low acid foods such as meat, poultry, and vegetables must be canned using a pressure canner because boiling water canners do not reach high enough temperatures to kill dangerous bacteria like *Clostridium botulinum*. Using a boiling water canner can leave these foods unsafe, with a risk of botulism poisoning.

Why people believe it: Many people think that boiling water canners are sufficient because they work well for high acid foods like fruits and pickles. Some traditional recipes or old practices may not clearly advise pressure canning.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

FALSE

HIGH RISK

Simply adding a little vinegar to low acid vegetables does not guarantee they become acidic enough for safe boiling-water canning. The acidity level must be very precise to prevent botulism risk, so home canners should use tested recipes designed for acidified foods or use pressure canning.

Why people believe it: People often think vinegar is a universal preservative that can make any food safe for water bath canning because vinegar is commonly used in pickling.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

FALSE

HIGH RISK

Venting the pressure canner for 10 minutes is essential to remove air from the canner chamber. Air trapped inside can prevent the proper temperature from being reached, causing under-processing and unsafe canned food.

Why people believe it: Many may think that once steam starts, the canner is ready, especially if the process seems fast. It can seem like an unnecessary delay.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

TRUE

MEDIUM RISK

Fermented pickles use good bacteria to produce acid gradually, which preserves the vegetables and adds flavor. This process naturally takes time at room temperature.

Why people believe it: Traditional fermentation has always involved waiting several weeks; it's a heritage method handed down in families and cultures.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

TRUE

LOW RISK

In quick pickles, salt affects flavor and texture but is not critical for safety if the vinegar concentration is maintained properly.

Why people believe it: It's common to think salt is always necessary for safety, but vinegar is the main acidifying agent in quick pickles.

Source: NCHFP Pickled eggs

FALSE

HIGH RISK

Simply adding more vinegar does not guarantee safety if the recipe's balance is off. Proper acid level, recipe proportions, and processing time are critical for safety.

Why people believe it: People often think that since vinegar is acidic and kills bacteria, more vinegar must be safer. This seems logical and is a common kitchen intuition.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

FALSE

HIGH RISK

Flavoring ingredients like garlic or onion do not replace the need for correct vinegar concentration or refrigeration for safety.

Why people believe it: Family recipes often include these flavorful add-ins and sometimes neglect refrigeration, assuming they add preservation effect.

Source: NCHFP Pickled eggs

FALSE

HIGH RISK

Salt is essential in fermented pickles to inhibit spoilage organisms and allow beneficial bacteria to thrive. Omitting salt can lead to unsafe products.

Why people believe it: Some people reduce salt for health reasons or believe salt is only for flavor, thinking the fermentation alone is sufficient.

Source: NCHFP Pickled eggs

Adding bottled lemon juice is recommended because it has a reliable acidity level that helps preserve safety by lowering pH and improves gel formation with pectin. Using fresh lemon juice or substituting vinegar can be inconsistent and unsafe.

Why people believe it: Traditionally, recipes call for lemon juice to balance sweetness and acidity, and home canners know acidity is crucial for safety.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

Using half-pint or pint jars helps jams and jellies set properly because larger jars cool more slowly and may stay too warm too long, causing the gel to fail. So, picking the right jar size is indeed important for a quality and safe product.

Why people believe it: This advice comes from pectin manufacturers and extension publications that recommend smaller jars for best setting results, but sometimes is misunderstood as a safety issue rather than quality.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

FALSE

HIGH RISK

While homemade pectin can sometimes be used, commercial pectin products are tested to ensure they work with specified sugar and acid levels for safe gel formation. Homemade or untested pectin substitutions risk under-processing or incorrect gel, leading to spoilage.

Why people believe it: Traditionally, people used natural methods for thickening jams and assume any pectin source is equally effective.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

FALSE

HIGH RISK

Adding thickeners before canning is not recommended because they can interfere with heat penetration and preservation, potentially causing unsafe jams. Instead, thicken jams by cooking or thickening after opening.

Why people believe it: People want to achieve thicker texture quickly and believe adding thickeners is an easy way to improve jam consistency.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

FALSE

HIGH RISK

You can reduce sugar safely in jam recipes, but you must use special low- or no-sugar pectins and follow adapted recipes carefully. Simply cutting sugar in a traditional recipe can cause jams to have poor texture and possibly be less safe. Using tested products and instructions for low-sugar jams ensures both good quality and safety.

Why people believe it: Traditional jam recipes have always used a lot of sugar, which acts as a preservative. This has led many to think sugar reduction is unsafe without considering modern pectin technology.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

TRUE

LOW RISK

Freezing fish soon after catching and icing it slowly through rigor mortis maintains quality better than freezing fish that has warmed or gone quickly through rigor. Poor handling before freezing causes toughness or off-flavors that freezing can't fix.

Why people believe it: Some think fish must fully 'relax' after rigor mortis before freezing to avoid damage.

Source: PNW 586 Home freezing seafood

TRUE

LOW RISK

Most fruits and vegetables remain high quality for 8 to 12 months when frozen at 0°F (-18°C) or below. Freezing at proper temperatures preserves nutrition and slows quality loss.

Why people believe it: People sometimes doubt if freezing preserves flavor and nutrients well or worry that freezing damages produce over time.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables

FALSE

HIGH RISK

Refreezing thawed food is not always safe. If the food has warmed above 40°F (5°C) during thawing, bacteria may have grown to unsafe levels, even if it looks or smells normal. Refreezing can trap bacteria and increase the risk of foodborne illness.

Why people believe it: Many people assume freezing kills all bacteria and that freezing again doesn't affect safety if the food seems okay.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables

FALSE

HIGH RISK

Frozen canned foods can still be safe if the container remains intact. Freezing may affect texture or cause bulging, but safety depends on the integrity of the can or jar. Carefully check for seals and damage before deciding to discard.

Why people believe it: Freezing can cause cans or jars to bulge or break, so it's commonly thought all frozen cans are unsafe.

Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home

FALSE

HIGH RISK

You can safely refrigerate large amounts of hot food if you speed cooling by dividing it into shallow containers or chilling in ice water first. This prevents the food from staying in the danger zone too long and protects all groceries in the fridge.

Why people believe it: People worry that putting hot food directly into the refrigerator warms the fridge and other foods, causing spoilage.

Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home

TRUE

HIGH RISK

Cooking meat to 160°F kills harmful pathogens like Salmonella and E. coli that might be present. Drying alone at low temperatures may not destroy these bacteria, so heating before or after dehydration ensures safer jerky.

Why people believe it: Some think drying at low temperatures is all that's needed because the meat becomes dry and leathery, and visible dryness indicates safety. This overlooks microbial survival.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

Forming a pellicle by air drying fish before smoking is an important step. It helps smoke flavors adhere evenly and also reduces the risk of surface spoilage during the smoking process.

Why people believe it: This step is a traditional smoking practice passed down in many recipes to improve texture and flavor, often described as essential for good smoked fish.

FALSE

HIGH RISK

Jerky must be dried at the right temperature (usually at least 130°F) to ensure harmful bacteria are destroyed. Just feeling dry is not enough to guarantee safety. If dried too slowly or at too low a temperature, bacteria may survive and multiply, leading to unsafe food.

Why people believe it: People often base safety on texture and dryness because dried appearance seems like preservation, and old family jerky recipes often lack temperature guidance.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

FALSE

HIGH RISK

Cold smoking below 90°F does not cook or kill bacteria effectively, so fish smoked this way must be refrigerated or frozen. Relying on smoke alone at low temperatures is unsafe as it does not prevent bacterial growth that causes spoilage and illness.

Why people believe it: Cold smoking is a traditional method thought to add preservative smoke flavor, and many recipes mention 'cold smoking' for flavor without temperature warnings.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

FALSE

HIGH RISK

Smoking adds flavor and some preservation qualities but is not sufficient to make meat or fish shelf-stable. Hot smoking should include cooking the product to a safe internal temperature, and smoked products usually require refrigeration or freezing.

Why people believe it: Many traditional recipes suggest smoking preserves food for long storage, and commercial smoked meats are often refrigerated, a detail home cooks miss.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home